

From the edge of the deal to the centre of the credit decision

Sara Yip already works inside the corporate-banking machine. The shortest route into credit is not another qualification; it is to convert that proximity into underwriting repetitions, while using her Applied Finance work to prove the analytical foundation is already there.

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The transition is a bridge, not a reset: Sara's existing corporate-client experience already covers the client, process and stakeholder side of banking; the missing span is applied underwriting.

Conceptual diagram based on the candidate's resume and stated target

SARA YIP is not trying to break into banking from the outside. She is already inside it. At UOB she manages onboarding and servicing for a portfolio of 50 corporate clients, supports transactions valued up to S\$900 million, and works across relationship management, AML, Operations, Legal and Tax. Before that, she worked at DBS as a business and data analyst. Her MSc in Applied Finance adds formal training in corporate finance, financial modelling and bank risk management.

That combination makes the transition credible. It does not, however, make her an experienced credit analyst. Her current resume does not yet show the activities that define underwriting: spreading financial statements, testing cash-flow repayment capacity, writing credit applications, structuring facilities, monitoring covenants, performing annual reviews or forming an independent borrower-risk view.

The strategy, therefore, is not to disguise the gap. It is to cross it deliberately.

The real positioning

Sara should be sold as an adjacent banking professional moving closer to the lending decision, not as a fresh graduate and not as an experienced underwriter.

Her profile has three unusually useful ingredients for a first credit move. First, she already understands the mechanics of corporate banking: onboarding, documentation, implementation, client servicing and cross-functional execution. Second, she has worked with corporate clients at meaningful scale. Third, she has returned to school for a finance degree rather than relying only on operational experience.

Those strengths are valuable because credit work does not happen in isolation. A good analyst must understand the borrower, the relationship, the product, the documentation path and the internal approval process. Sara is already familiar with much of that environment.

What she lacks is the portion of the workflow where the bank asks a different question: not "Can we onboard and service this client?" but "Should we lend, on what terms, and what can go wrong?"

The bottleneck is no longer finance education. It is applied credit experience.

That distinction should shape every decision she makes over the next year. A role with a slightly less impressive title but real credit-paper responsibility is strategically superior to another corporate-banking support role that leaves underwriting untouched.

Do not send her back into student mode

Sara already has a master's degree in Applied Finance. Another broad qualification is unlikely to solve the hiring problem. The next signal employers need is applied evidence: company analysis, cash-flow reasoning, credit writing and eventually real borrower cases.

The practical implication is that credentials should now be subordinate to repetitions. If she can obtain even partial responsibility for annual reviews, borrower financial analysis or sections of a credit application inside UOB, those experiences will carry more weight than another certificate.

Exhibit 1

Sara is already strong on banking adjacency; the missing evidence sits in underwriting

Requirement	Evidence today	Position
Corporate-banking environment	UOB cash management; prior DBS banking experience	Strong
Corporate-client exposure	Portfolio of 50 clients; transactions up to S\$900m	Strong
RM and control-function coordination	RM, AML, Operations, Legal and Tax stakeholders	Strong
Financial education	MSc Applied Finance; corporate finance, modelling, bank risk	Strong
Company analysis	Equity-analysis valuation project	Developing
Financial-statement analysis	Academic evidence available; professional evidence not yet shown	Developing
Credit underwriting	No demonstrated borrower underwriting in current resume	Gap
Credit-paper writing	Not demonstrated	Gap
Facility structuring / covenant monitoring	Not demonstrated	Gap

Source: candidate resume supplied 6 October 2026; assessment is advisory interpretation.

The highest-probability move

The best first target is not the most prestigious external vacancy. It is the role that gives Sara repeated exposure to real credit decisions.

The first route to pursue is internal mobility at UOB. An internal hiring manager does not need to be convinced that Sara can operate within a bank, navigate controls or manage corporate stakeholders. The decision is narrower: can she be trained into credit?

That is a much easier proposition than asking an external bank to overlook the absence of underwriting experience altogether.

Her internal search should therefore focus on Credit Analyst, Credit Management, Credit Risk, Portfolio Management and relationship-support roles that contain real credit responsibility. She should also look at commercial-banking associate roles where analysts prepare financial spreads, annual reviews or credit applications alongside relationship managers.

The title matters less than the work. The first successful move is the one that produces a new set of verbs for the resume: analysed, modelled, assessed, structured, recommended, monitored.

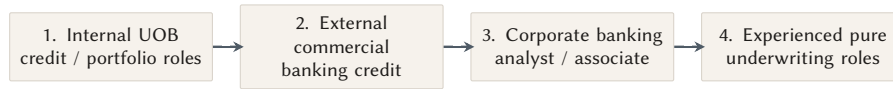
The objective is not title optimisation. It is to acquire underwriting repetitions.

Externally, commercial banking is likely to provide the most forgiving bridge. The work often combines lending with cash management, trade finance and relationship coverage, so her existing product and client experience has immediate relevance. Corporate-banking analyst or associate roles can also work when they mix coverage support with credit rather than demanding independent underwriting from day one.

Vacancies for fully experienced underwriters should be secondary targets until she has genuine cases behind her. Applying selectively is sensible; building the entire search around them is not.

Exhibit 2

The target-role ladder should maximise credit exposure, not title prestige



Conceptual priority ladder based on transition probability and learning value.

Turn the equity project into a credit bridge

The SMU valuation report should not be disguised as credit work. It should be used as proof that Sara can already analyse a company.

The equity-analysis project is strategically useful because it can demonstrate financial-statement analysis, forecasting, valuation judgement and company/industry research. Those capabilities transfer directly into credit even though the objective changes.

The equity investor asks: how much could this company be worth, and what could create upside? The lender asks: what can impair repayment, how severe could the downside be, and what protections are required?

Sara should therefore take the same company she valued at SMU and re-analyse it from the creditor's perspective. Historical financial statements remain the starting point, but the emphasis changes. Revenue growth matters less than cash conversion. Margin expansion matters less than the durability of EBITDA and free cash flow. Capital structure, debt maturities, refinancing risk, working-capital volatility and downside re-

silience move to the foreground.

The exercise should end with a lending decision rather than a target price: would she lend, how much, for what purpose, for approximately what tenor, and subject to what protections?

What the second version should add

Rework the equity case to include leverage, liquidity, interest coverage, debt-service capacity, free cash flow, debt maturities, downside scenarios, sources of repayment, key risks, mitigants and a lending recommendation.

Done well, this becomes an interview asset rather than a resume ornament. Sara can discuss one company twice: first as an equity analyst, then as a creditor. That contrast is an efficient way to prove she understands the different objective function of lending.

Build the missing toolkit

Sara does not need specialist leveraged-finance modelling before her first move. She does need to be fluent in the language of repayment risk.

Her technical preparation should be anchored in a simple sequence: understand the business, reconstruct the cash flows, map the debt burden, stress the assumptions, then decide whether repayment remains credible.

She should be able to move comfortably from the income statement into operating cash flow and free cash flow; explain why accounting profit can coexist with financial distress; assess working-capital behaviour; and interpret leverage, liquidity and coverage ratios in context rather than as isolated thresholds.

She also needs working familiarity with revolving facilities, term loans, bilateral and syndicated lending, guarantees, trade-finance facilities and common covenant structures. The objective is not product trivia. It is to understand

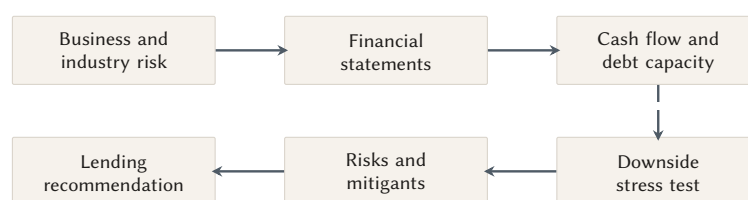
how a bank can shape exposure when the underlying company is not risk-free.

Equity asks what the upside is. Credit asks what can stop repayment.

A single independent credit memorandum would be an effective capstone. Choose a listed company, analyse its historical statements and industry, build a base and downside case, assess debt-service capacity, identify risks and mitigants, and finish with a clear approve/decline recommendation plus indicative structure.

Exhibit 3

A first-principles credit workflow turns finance knowledge into an underwriting decision



Conceptual underwriting workflow.

Use the network before the job board

Because Sara already works inside a bank, informational access is one of her strongest advantages.

Her networking effort should begin inside UOB: credit analysts and credit managers first, then corporate and commercial RMs who originate loans, followed by portfolio-management and risk professionals. The goal is not to ask strangers for jobs. It is to learn how the internal credit workflow actually operates and where someone in her current seat can contribute.

High-value questions are operational. What portion of a credit application does an analyst own? How are financial statements spread? What makes a first-year analyst useful? Which products matter most? What commonly prevents an internal candidate from transferring? Where could she help on an annual review or

borrower update without crossing responsibility lines?

Ten such conversations can reveal both the skill gap and the hidden job market inside the bank. They may also create opportunities to shadow or contribute before a formal vacancy exists.

Externally, networking should be narrower and more evidence-led. Once Sara has rebuilt her equity case as a creditor and completed one independent credit memo, those artifacts give the conversation substance: she is no longer merely asking how to enter credit; she can show how she is preparing to do the work.

The next twelve months

The plan should be judged by one outcome: does Sara finish the year with genuine borrower-analysis experience?

The first two months are for positioning and technical conversion. Finalise the credit-oriented resume, recover the full details of the SMU valuation project, rebuild that case from the lender's perspective, and begin internal conversations with UOB credit professionals.

Months two to four are for proof. Complete one independent credit memorandum, practise written credit cases and technical interviews, and actively seek credit-adjacent tasks in the current role. External applications can begin, but should be concentrated on commercial-banking and mixed coverage/credit roles rather than experienced-underwriter vacancies.

Months four to eight are for the actual move. If internal mobility stalls, widen the external search to regional banks, foreign banks and mid-market teams that may value her corporate-banking adjacency. The preferred job is any credible role in which she will repeatedly analyse borrowers and write or support credit recommendations.

By months eight to twelve, the resume should begin replacing academic evidence with professional evidence: borrowers analysed, credit applications supported, annual reviews completed, facility sizes, sectors covered, covenants monitored and recommendations made.

Exhibit 4

The transition succeeds when academic evidence is progressively replaced by real credit cases

0–2 months	Reposition resume; convert SMU valuation into creditor analysis; start UOB credit networking; learn core credit mechanics.
2–4 months	Complete independent credit memo; practise written cases; seek annual-review / borrower-analysis exposure; apply selectively.
4–8 months	Secure internal transfer or external role with real underwriting responsibility; prioritise work content over title.
8–12 months	Replace academic signals with professional credit cases, portfolio exposure and evidence of judgement.

Career roadmap based on the candidate's current profile and target transition.

What good looks like

The transition is complete when Sara no longer needs to explain why her background is relevant; the credit work itself makes the case.

Two or three years of genuine underwriting experience would open several paths. Relationship management is the natural destination if she enjoys clients and origination; her cash-management background would then become a differentiator. Senior credit or credit risk suits a more analytical preference. Portfolio management sits between the two. Specialised lending can come later if she develops deeper modelling and transaction experience.

Those choices do not need to be made now. The immediate problem is much simpler: cross the boundary from corporate-banking support into actual lending and credit decision work.

Sara's profile is already coherent enough that she should not spend the next year manufacturing a new identity. Her career story is stronger when it remains continuous: engineering and quality built process discipline; DBS added an-

alytics; UOB added corporate-client and banking exposure; the MSc supplied financial analysis; credit is the logical next move closer to risk judgement and capital allocation.

The shortest route into credit is to make the next role contain the work that the current resume cannot yet claim.

That is the strategy in one sentence. Everything else – resume edits, coursework, networking and interview preparation – should be evaluated by whether it makes that move more likely.

Notes and source basis

1. Candidate resume supplied in this conversation on 6 October 2026. It records UOB cash-management experience from September 2022, a portfolio of 50 corporate clients, transaction values up to S\$900 million, prior DBS business/data analysis experience, and an MSc in Applied Finance at Singapore Management University.
2. User-provided clarification in this conversation: students in the Applied Finance programme complete an equity-analysis valuation report; this brief treats that project as transferable analytical evidence, not as professional credit underwriting.
3. Career recommendations are advisory interpretation based on the candidate's stated target of commercial or corporate banking credit in Singapore. No professional underwriting experience is assumed where the resume does not evidence it.